A THORNY AGENDA

CABINET FORMATION
There are 163 BJP MLAs, many of whom are very senior and have huge experience, compared to the novice CM. Managing portfolio allocations will be a challenge

BIG-TICKET SUBSIDIES
Programmes like the Ladli Behna Yojana will see an outflow of Rs 11,000 crore this fiscal; another Rs 1,000 crore will be needed to subsidise gas cylinders. Wheat/paddy procurement will make the biggest dent: MP will have to pay the bonus on the 10-plus million tonne wheat it hopes to procure in the coming season. Approx. cost: Rs 4,250 cr.

LOW STATE FINANCES
MP has an accumulated loan of Rs 3.31 lakh crore and a per capita debt of Rs 41,000. Total debt could be Rs 3.9 lakh crore by the end of the fiscal

NEW BUREAUCRACY
With the previous chief secretary Iqbal Singh Bains and CM Shivraj Chouhan both demitting office, there is a vacuum in terms of administrative experience at the helm. CM Yadav has to get a new team of bureaucrats in place who will have his back

importance of taking along so many stalwarts, embarked on a mission to call on many of them. The visits to the houses of former home minister Narottam Mishra, speaker designate Narendra Singh Tomar, former CM Uma Bharti and former minister Gopal Bhargava in Bhopal suggest a keen realisation that he needs their support if he has to run a smooth ship. Critically, the new CM will also have to work out his own style of functioning if he wants to come out of the shadow of ex-CM Chouhan's 16-year legacy. An indication of this came on December 13 when, in one of his first orders, Yadav ordered the removal of loudspeakers from temples and mosques. The other diktat was to cancel the bail of habitual offenders and put controls over the public sale of meat.

In his early years, Yadav helped out at a tea and bhajia stall run by his father Poonamchand. The family owned farmland near Ujjain, which they still cultivate. As per his poll affidavit, his fortunes have improved substantially in the past decade and a half. His two elder brothers own stone-crushing mills and are into real estate. Sister Kalavati is a six-term corporator and, in August 2022, became the first woman chairperson of the Ujjain Municipal Corporation.

Yadav has two sons and a daughter. While son Abhimanyu and daughter Akanksha are doctors, the second son Vaibhav is a lawyer and seems politically inclined. The family is setting up a super-speciality hospital in Ujjain. "Mohan is clear-headed and always thinks long-term. I have known him since our days in the ABVP when we participated in a movement to get the government to take over the Madhav Science College," says Ujjain resident Rajesh Agarwal.

THE HOT SEAT

Yadav took oath as CM on December 13 along with two deputy chief ministers, Jagdish Devda and Rajendra Shukla. After the excitement over the surprise elevation recedes, he will find a large number of challenges waiting for him, some of them financial, others in the political and administrative domains. To begin with, the state does not have a full-time chief secretary, with the seniormost IAS officer, Veera Rana, holding charge for the moment.

The BJP will also have to make good on its poll promises, some of which have enormous financial implications.

AN INDICATION THAT CM YADAV WAS HIS OWN MAN CAME IN ONE OF HIS FIRST ORDERS—REMOVAL OF LOUDSPEAKERS FROM TEMPLES, MOSQUES

The Ladli Behna Yojana, which entails a monthly payment of Rs 1,250 to nearly 13 million women in the state, is already in force and involves an outflow of around Rs 11,000 crore this fiscal year. Besides this, another Rs 1,000 crore is needed to subsidise gas cylinders.

The biggest outflow will be when the state commences procurement of paddy and wheat at MSP plus bonus rates. The BJP manifesto had announced wheat procurement at Rs 2,700 per quintal and paddy at Rs 3,100. There is already talk that the manifesto does not say when the rates would become effective. However, denial of these rates in the upcoming wheat season could impact the BJP's fortunes in the LS election, not to mention the loss of face as they were 'PM Modi *ki* guarantees'. It is expected that the state will procure 10-13 million tonnes of wheat in the upcoming season if buying takes place at Rs 2,700 per quintal (the MSP is paid by the Centre). The state will have to spend Rs 4,250 per tonne (the bonus), not to mention the amount spent on logistics. In a cryptic reply to a question on whether he intends to continue with the ongoing schemes, the new CM said, "I will examine all the schemes...if the scheme is good, it is a priority to keep them going."

Meanwhile, continuity in administration is likely to be an issue with chief secretary Iqbal Singh Bains demitting office. The new CM is also relatively fresh, having become a minister for the first time just three years ago. Expect his mettle to be put to the test very soon. ■